

intended that way? Perhaps it was, and at any rate interpretations always abound. But how about “distancing” as a wonderful flight of the imagination, as a journey like Gulliver’s or of Alice’s, as a metaphorical attempt to estrange oneself from a familiar world in order to better appreciate its wonders — and reveal its cruelties. I once spoke of “anthropology as a frame of mind” (1993), and I hope that I am not misinterpreting Weick’s intentions when I read his “mindset” in this light. Sentimentalizing will not help the world; keen attention to the details of life, and to the way these are made sense of, might.

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Gender, Managers, and Organizations, by Yvonne Due Billing and Mats Alvesson (Berlin: Walter du Gruyter, 1994), 260 pp., ISBN 3-11-012984-1.

Gender, Managers, and Organizations by Yvonne Due Billing and Mats Alvesson provides, as stated on the back cover, a general introduction as well as an overview and a critical discussion of theory and research on gender, feminism, women in management and organizational studies. This is a topic which is much discussed in the popular debate and it bears the stamp of political correctness. These circumstances explain the great number of so-called experts and consultants who are producing courses, lectures, books and articles on different aspects of gender-and-management or, women-and-management. It is therefore of great importance that solid research is done and published, to alleviate the worst of the misunderstandings.

The topic of this book embraces fields of knowledge that have until now been divided between different disciplines and angles, which put the questions differently. The authors take a broad approach to incorporate both working life, society, organizational characteristics and actors on different hierarchical levels. Their main interest is in managers at the middle level.

The book is divided into three parts. The first presents *Gender perspectives*, the second *Three case studies* and the last *Discussion and reflections*. The part on gender perspective is needed as a background to the case studies. The organizational realities cannot be understood without some knowledge about the position of women (and men) in society and on the labour market. The gender division in education and work is presented in words and figures. Various models and theories for understanding the construction of gender differences are presented and discussed. These are of very different kinds: macro-sociological explanatory models, including a Marxist approach, the concept of patriarchy and the dual systems theory, middle-range and micro-sociological explanatory models, organizational culture models and role theories, the theory, of

psychoanalytical and sociological socialization etc. The authors do not give preference to any one before the other, and end by declaring that they will refer to the sources whenever they feel it is relevant. Pure biological explanations — although they are very popular nowadays — are excluded. The main problem about biological factor studies is that they “have been misused in the name of science”. On the other hand the authors state that although social scientists emphasize the social and cultural construction of gender, they should be aware of “the risk of social reductionism” (p. 46).

The three last chapters in the first part describe some earlier studies of similarities and differences between female and male managers, the way to and from managerial positions and ideas about women and managers. The part on similarities and differences is mainly concerned with leadership style and job reactions. The main conclusion is that it is hard to say anything at all on the sex and gender question, as the structural circumstances for leaders, and their selection and socialization are so strong. “One cannot maintain that women and men are basically alike or differ regarding qualities, motivation, ideas about themselves etc. pertaining to this field” (p. 86).

The case studies were carried out in the Danish National Board of Social Welfare, the Scandinavian Airlines Systems and the Danish Ministry of Social Affairs. Interviews were held with around 15 people, both women and men, in each one of the three organizations. The descriptions and interpretations concern a number of aspects such as history and production, the numerical proportions of women and men, common personnel and organizational conditions such as recruiting policy and cultural characteristics, career patterns, women’s prospects as regards managerial positions compared with men’s, and general gender perspectives on the organization and gender differences in connection with leadership style. Each organization is presented separately, after which they are analysed and compared both with each other and with previous research and existing theories. The organizations were chosen because of their differences in certain important respects.

The employees of the Danish National Board of Social Welfare have on average a lower level of education than other comparable administration workforces of a typical female kind. The organization has rather low status. The atmosphere is described as caring, and the men in the organization are considered to be sensitive and empathetic. Masculine stereotypes are not highly valued. Career possibilities are limited. Despite the egalitarian image, the work tasks — and thus the employees — are divided into a A- and a B-team, with the first having the better and more challenging jobs. The division is said to be based on personality rather than gender. Recruiting for management positions occurs mainly by asking people to apply, and here people does mean people — not just men. There are as many female as male managers. Differences between the sexes are seldom noticed. It seems to be an organization where equality and “a synthesis of ‘female’ and ‘male’ cultural elements” really do exist.

SAS with its ‘technical values’ seems in many respects to be the complete opposite of the Ministry of Social Affairs. Management espouse an interest in ‘female characteristics’ and a fifty-fifty distribution of the sexes in work groups is often sought as this is thought to give a good working climate. The opinion is a consequence of the fact that women and men are often described as having distinct and different characteristics. There are relatively few women at the higher hierarchical levels, and the sex segregation between sectors is strict. Men are pilots, technicians and managers at higher levels while women are in service jobs and are over represented at the lower levels. Women have jobs in which it is hard to develop and to make themselves visible and they apply less often than men for managerial positions. Why this is so is commented upon by the people interviewed, and an interesting difference between women and men is revealed: women emphasize factors related to work and the role of managers, while men emphasize women’s

personal situation and psychology. This opportunity structure, say the authors, is a cultural construction while also itself affecting culture. In SAS male and female leaders are not described as being alike. They are said to negotiate in different ways representing different cultures. So even if SAS is often spoken of as a company that has undergone great changes and is now progressive and modern, when it comes to gender and gender relations it has remained very stable.

The Danish Ministry of Foreign Affairs was chosen because it was very male-dominated. Although around 50% of the workforce are women, only 3% of the top positions are held by them. The Ministry enjoys high status, and all managers have a university education. The career orientation is obvious, and applications for management positions are many. Women with university degrees are as career-oriented as men. After some time in the Ministry, a period abroad is the rule. Work in the Ministry is a lifestyle. Gender is not on the agenda there. It is not considered important to the operations at the workplace, and gender discrimination is not mentioned. The small number of women in top positions is explained by factors outside the organization. The authors do see differences, even though the main impression is of similarities. They find that the female managers have to some extent different opinions about what a managerial position involves, and they seem to have a more relaxed attitude towards work. The authors also find former employees who spoke of discrimination toward women due to tacit premises. But, write the authors, for an organization like the Ministry it is important to “promote those who are ‘safe’ — perceived as reliable and predictable” — that is men.

In brief it can be said that most of the results were more or less expected, but some do challenge common knowledge. For instance, the authors point out that the situation in the National Board of Social Welfare seems to deny the deterministic variants of the patriarchal theories. The main impression of the case studies is one of similarity rather than difference when it comes to management styles in all three organizations. It is, rather, motivation that differs. There is a dialectic relation between organizations and society. To explain women’s (and men’s) situation in organizations, three factors are identified: individual psychological, organizational and family conditions. The first includes qualifications and ability to handle the cultural context. The organizational factors include structures like gender composition, the nature of the work and values. Four process-related phenomena are emphasized: (a) selective perception; (b) homo-social reproduction; (c) social games and bias as a result of different rules of interpretation for men and women, and (d) tokenism. But when gender in working life is being discussed it is not enough to restrict oneself to the organizations in questions. The situation outside work, in people’s hopes and families, cannot be excluded.

In the final chapter the authors broaden their approach, with the help of the findings from the case studies. Their first argument concerns gender bias in organizations, which is a historical fact. The problems women meet are a consequence of the “prestructuring of management and organizations” which demands attributes that bear a very male stamp. This can change as gender is constantly constructed and reconstructed — but it is not an obvious goal for women to become managers, so long as organizations look as they do. The authors also remind us that organizations can look quite different from above and from below, indicating that it is problematic to talk about women, or men, as one homogeneous group. More than one kind of femininity is constructed in every organization.

The authors point out the importance of understanding how different parts of organizations symbolize gender in various ways, if we are to understand organizations and the way they work. The symbolism is connected with organizational type, level, function, profession, number etc. Gender discrimination can best be understood when both macro-culture and micro-cultures are considered. But the subject, the actor, always calls for attention as well.

This book takes a popular subject and makes things a little bit more complicated. It connects the topic to mainstream organizational research, showing how this can be better understood if gender and gender symbolism are integrated into descriptions and analyses. It is therefore an important book for both political and scientific reasons.

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Project Management in the Process Industries, by Roy Whittaker. Chichester, England: (John Wiley & Sons Ltd, 1995), 372 pp.

This is not a book intended primarily for researchers on organizations. Rather, it represents an attempt to provide a condensation of extensive practical experience of project management in the process industries. The author, who has some 30 years experience as a project manager within the chemical industry, attempts to provide the reader with useful insights into the running of major projects and ways of avoiding serious mistakes. He has been responsible for some major ICI capital investments in the U.K. and internationally. He was employed by ICI from 1955 until 1992, when he left to become an independent consultant in project management and found he could no longer resist the urge to "commit his experiences to paper".

The book addresses most of the standard issues in the project management field. The various stages of project work, from project definition to the final result are analysed in detail. Planning, design and project cost management are described, and a special point is made of the fact that the process industries are assumed to operate in a very competitive environment. Various aspects of arranging for competitive bids, choosing between inhouse and external contractors, and establishing contract relationships are thus treated at length in the book, at least in comparison with the standard project management literature. It should be added that the content is very much coloured by the author's substantial experience of overseas projects.

The investments described are conceived as a continuing part of the process manufacturer's business. This conception clearly affects the recommendations which the author offers to the readers. Essentially the book is about how to get good routines to function even better in this particular setting. The notion of the repetitiveness of project work and the striving for efficiency clearly guides the author in his ambition to offer advice.

There are essentially two ways of evaluating a book of this character. The first alternative is to view it as what it was obviously intended to be and what it was essentially written for, i.e. as a guide to investment project management in the process industries, and then to evaluate it in those terms. The other alternative is to view it as a description of the conventional wisdom in the field, i.e. as the prevalent social construction of reality in the process industries.

To take the first alternative first, the book should be quite useful to practitioners seeking good advice on how to do things. The book is certainly not excessively committed to check lists about what the practical project manager ought to remember; on the contrary it also presents most of the logics, and the convincing empirical evidence, to back its claims. Moreover, the book is very well written. At times it makes really amusing reading, seducing the reader if not to outright